Teaching Statement

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Over seven years as a teaching assistant I have taught economics at every level UBC offers, from first-year principles to the PhD microeconomic theory sequence (ECON 600 and 601), which I have taught every year since 2021. In Summer 2026 I was the instructor for the department's MA and PhD Math Camp, developing material the department intends to build future camps on. Teaching the PhD core, the most technically demanding material in the curriculum, alongside first-year and third-year sections has taught me to present material at the level each audience requires.

I am prepared to teach any course in the undergraduate curriculum, including macroeconomics and econometrics. My strongest interest and deepest preparation are in microeconomics, from principles through game theory, information economics, and auctions and market design, and, at the graduate level, in mathematics for economists and the microeconomic theory core. I find teaching deeply rewarding. Introducing students to economics is among the parts of academic work I value most, and I intend for it to remain central to my career.

Teaching philosophy

At a university, students lead their own learning. Understanding is something they build through their own work, and no lecture can do that work for them. The instructor's role is to make that work possible, and I see it as three tasks.

The first is to give students a reason to do the work. Effort that students choose to make depends on seeing why the material matters, so motivation is where teaching starts rather than an addition to it. The second is to set out clearly what students are expected to understand and to what level. Students leading their own learning need to know where they are going, and a clear target lets them judge their own progress instead of waiting for an exam to judge it. The third is to help them past the points where they get stuck. These are the moments when self-directed learning is most likely to stall, and where an instructor adds the most.

The three tasks depend on one another. Motivation without a clear target produces effort that drifts. A clear target without support leaves students facing the hardest parts alone. Support is only useful once students are invested enough to want it and know enough about the goal to see where they are stuck.

Teaching practice

I carry out these tasks mostly through problems. A tool is easier to motivate when students first see the problem it was built to solve, whether an academic question or a practical one, so in my sections the material is introduced through questions, mostly from problem sets and past exams. We solve them together, with me calling on students as we go. Working a problem also tells students where they stand. A problem they can finish confirms what they understand, and the point where they get stuck shows them, and me, which part of the general idea they have not yet grasped. Handing students the reasoning in this way does not depend on a small room, and the same principle has been applied successfully in large introductory economics courses.[1]

Proofs are a core part of theory courses. Intuition comes first and the technical steps second, because the aim of a proof is not to take students through each step but to give them enough understanding of the result that they feel able to use it. I present a result in four stages. I begin with what it says and where it applies, either by showing what would go wrong without it, so that students see what it gives them, or through a graphical or numerical illustration where one exists. I then explain why the result is not obvious, which identifies the

[1] Denny, E. (2014), "Reinterpreting the economics textbook: A student assignment," *International Review of Economics Education* 16, 100–110.

core fact the proof has to establish. Next I go through the intuition of the proof, built on those first two stages. Only then do I turn to the technical details and the formal argument. The same approach applies to abstract analytical results at any level.

In my tutorials I present one clean, linear solution first and save alternative routes for the end. A clean solution shows students how an argument should go, and in the PhD core I also want them to recognize when one does not. For some time I have presented proofs that are correct in their approach but omit a few necessary and subtle steps, and asked students to find where the argument is incomplete. This year I have started generating flawed proofs with weaker AI models for the same exercise. Reading a plausible argument and finding where it fails is among the most valuable skills a graduate student can take from a theory course, and lectures do not train it.

Finally, helping students past the hard parts depends on knowing where those parts are, and students know far more about what they do not understand than an instructor can observe. Much of what I do outside the classroom is meant to bring that knowledge out. In a class of twenty I work at making students comfortable with me, through a casual manner and an interest in their lives beyond the course, so that they will bring me even their small questions. When they do, I try to reconstruct how they were thinking before I say anything, because the useful answer is the correct solution attached to the place where their reasoning went wrong. In a large class the useful connection is among the students. In ECON 101 I put the whole section into one group chat and routed every question through it. Most were answered by classmates before I saw them, and my job became confirming the answer or adding a small correction. Students who would never have emailed a teaching assistant asked freely there.

Teaching large classes

Most of my teaching has been in sections of about twenty, and not every practice that works at that size survives in a lecture hall. The question channel from ECON 101 is the one I am most confident will scale, because I have already run it in a larger class. In a large ECON 101 or intermediate microeconomics (ECON 301) course I would route all questions through one moderated forum,[2] with a small amount of bonus credit for correct answers to classmates. This makes the strongest students a resource for the whole class without assigned groups, whose composition is hard to get right and which students rarely welcome. Class time would remain devoted to lectures and worked problems, and I would keep calling on students as a problem is solved, so that a large room follows the reasoning step by step rather than receiving only the answer.

Evidence of teaching effectiveness

Course	Years	Sections	Responses	Median, /5	Good or very good
ECON 600/601 (PhD micro theory)	2021–2026	10	104	4.8–5.0	100%
ECON 514 (information and incentives)	2021	1	7	4.8	100%
ECON 101 (principles of micro)	2020, 2025	3	34	4.5–4.9	92–100%
ECON 303, 355 (intermediate micro, trade)	2019–2020	2	44	4.5–4.7	70–74%

Across the sixteen reports, an average of 96% of responding students rated my overall contribution good or very good. I received the Vancouver School of Economics Agustín Beltrán Award for Excellence in Teaching, the department's award for teaching assistants, in 2024, 2025 and 2026. My teaching dossier gives the full results, sample materials and my other contributions to teaching, and is also online at william96123.github.io/teaching.

[2] Barile, L., and A. Ghosh (2026), "Understanding online peer-assisted learning with forums in the 'digital era'," *Journal of Economic Education*, published online 29 July 2026.